BE READY!

Children's Lesson for the First Sunday of Advent
Mark 13:24-37

ADVENT THEME:

Hope — waiting for Jesus with excitement and readiness

ADVENT WREATH ACTIVITY:

Leader says:

"Today we begin Advent—a time when we get ready for Jesus! Each week we light a new candle. The first candle is the candle of Hope. Hope means we believe something good is coming… even if we can't see it yet!"

"This first candle reminds us of the hope we have because Jesus will come again, just like He promised."

Light the candle

"Jesus, thank You for giving us hope. Help us be ready for You by loving others and trusting You every day. Fill our hearts with Your light as we begin Advent. Amen."

"Pass the Hope"

Have children sit in a circle and pass a small glowing candle (or paper star).

Each child says one short hopeful thing like:

"I can have hope because Jesus loves me."

"I can have hope because God is with me."

"I can have hope because Jesus is coming again."

When the item comes back around, say:
“That’s what hope looks like—sharing Jesus’ light with one another!”

Option:

Attached Advent Wreath Coloring Sheet. Might color one candle each week.

INTRODUCTION:

Say:

“Have you ever waited for something exciting? Maybe a birthday, Christmas morning, or a visit from a friend? You don’t know the exact moment it’s going to happen, but you’re excited and ready!”

Take out the flashlight.

“Let’s pretend we’re going on a night walk and waiting for someone to come get us. We don’t know the exact time, but we keep a flashlight ready so when they come, we can see clearly. We stay prepared!”

READ OR RETELL THE PASSAGE: Mark 13:24-37

Say:

“In the Bible, Jesus tells His friends something really important. He says that one day He will come back again. But here’s the interesting part—no one knows the exact day or time! Not the angels, not anyone. Only God the Father knows.”

“Jesus says because we don’t know when He’s coming, we should live every day ready—like watching, waiting, and keeping our hearts full of love for Him.”

LESSON POINTS:

A. Jesus Will Come Again

“When we light the first Advent candle, we remember hope—the hope that Jesus will keep His promise and return.”

B. We Don't Know When—So We Stay Ready

"Jesus says to stay awake and be prepared. That means:

- living like Jesus every day,
- being kind,
- praying,
- loving others,
- and trusting Him."

C. Being Ready Is Not Scary—It's Exciting!

"It's not like waiting for something bad. It's like waiting for the best surprise ever! Jesus is coming to make everything right."

SIMPLE ILLUSTRATION: "THE READY BAG":

Object Needed: A small backpack with a few 'ready' items inside (snack, Bible, small water bottle, flashlight)

Say:
"I packed a little 'ready bag.' When we go on a trip, we pack things we need. When we follow Jesus, our hearts have a 'ready bag' too!"

Pull items out:

Bible: "We read God's Word to know Him."

Snack: "God gives us what we need each day."

Water: "Jesus fills us with His love."

Flashlight: "Jesus helps us walk in the light."

"Being ready for Jesus means keeping our hearts full of the things He gives us."

RESPONSE QUESTION:

Ask the kids:

"What is one way YOU can be ready for Jesus this week?"

(Examples: helping someone, praying before bed, being kind at school, reading the Bible, listening to parents.)

CLOSING PRAYER

“Jesus, thank You for the hope we have because You will come again. Help us be ready—not scared, but excited! Help us love You and others every day. Amen.”

Advent “Ready Lantern” Craft

A reminder to stay awake, stay ready, and shine for Jesus!

Supplies Needed

- 1 sheet of construction paper (any color)
- Scissors
- Glue or tape
- Markers/crayons
- Optional: battery tea light, stickers, stars

Instructions

1. Fold the Paper

Fold a sheet of construction paper **hot-dog style** (long ways).

2. Draw the “Light Strips”

On the folded edge, draw lines straight up toward the open edge, stopping about an inch from the top.
These will become slits that open to let the “light” shine.

3. Cut the Slits

Cut along the lines (but don’t cut all the way to the top).

4. Open and Roll

Open the paper back up and **roll it into a cylinder**, with the slits running top-to-bottom.
Tape or glue the ends to make a lantern shape.

5. Create a Handle

Cut a small strip of paper and tape it to the top as a handle.

6. Decorate With Hope!

Let kids decorate with:

- Stars
- Stickers
- Words like: **“Hope”**, **“Be Ready!”**, **“Jesus is Coming!”**
- Drawings of candles, hearts, or eyes watching/looking.

Optional

Place a **battery tea light** inside to make it glow!
This visually reinforces the message: **We shine the light of Jesus as we stay ready for Him.**